154 deaths, and 50 militants were captured. The assault resulted in pro-Taliban rebels along the Pak–Afghan border, breaching a ten-month-old peace agreement with the Pakistani government. This event triggered the Third Waziristan War, which marked another surge in militancy and violence in Pakistan, resulting in more than 3,000 casualties.

Many analysts viewed that the situation could have been tackled by the local administration at initial stages without the assistance of the army; however, it was allowed to settle for six months, by which time it reached a level where the army operation would seem the only viable option. However, even at that time, many of them preferred the Elite Police Force to take effective control of the situation. When the situation worsened, the politicians tried to find a negotiated settlement. However, the ruling party leaders, Ch. Shujaat Hussain and Ijaz-ul-Haq, had to cut a sorry figure when military operation was launched while they were engaged in talks with the holed up cleric leader Maulana Abdul Rashid Ghazi (*The Daily Times*, 2009).

General Musharraf's strategy was to create a situation that could be resolved through the army. He wanted the international community, especially the US, to believe that only he could tackle these militants. The army was his constituency on which he could survive and thrive. Secondly, he tried to emulate Zia-ul-Haq's Afghan policy to get the US aid and support for countering terrorism through army action. He even boasted of earning millions of dollars by arresting 657 Al Qaeda activists (Musharraf, 2006).

The 304-page report of the Lal Masjid Commission, although criticised for not providing the complete data, blamed former president Pervez Musharraf, former Prime Minister Shaukat Aziz and the members of his cabinet for being indirectly responsible for the Lal Masjid tragic incident. However, the former Prime Minister Ch. Shujaat Hussain, the former Prime Minister Shaukat Aziz, Tariq Azeem and cabinet members held the former President Pervez Musharraf accountable for the Lal Masjid operation. According to the ex-prime ministers and cabinet members, the Lal Masjid operation could have been avoided by adopting some other option.

TV talk show host and journalist Hamid Mir, who had been part of the negotiation process between the Lal Masjid clerics and the government, stated in his article that Musharraf wanted to stage a big drama in Islamabad, whereas the politicians in his government did not want him to